

98 Josiah

The boy king who found the Book of the Law and turned Judah back to God.

Grandson of Manasseh, the most wicked of Judah's kings, Josiah became its most wholehearted reformer. Named in prophecy three centuries before his birth, he took the throne at eight. When a forgotten scroll of God's Law was found in the temple, he wept, gathered the nation, and led the most thorough return to God in Judah's history.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Yoshiyahu</i> , "the LORD supports" or "the LORD heals"
<i>Family</i>	Son of King Amon; mother Jedidah (2 Kings 22:1)
<i>Reign</i>	c. 640–609 BC; crowned at 8, reigned 31 years
<i>Death</i>	Age 39, in battle against Pharaoh Neco at Megiddo
<i>Sons</i>	Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Zedekiah (1 Chronicles 3:15)
<i>Key people</i>	Hilkiah, Shaphan, Huldah, Jeremiah, Zephaniah
<i>Main passages</i>	2 Kings 22–23; 2 Chronicles 34–35
<i>New Testament</i>	Named once, in Jesus' genealogy (Matthew 1:10–11)

"And like unto him was there no king before him, that turned to the LORD with all his heart, and with all his soul, and with all his might ... neither after him arose there any like him."

2 Kings 23:25, KJV

The life of Josiah

Dates are approximate (BC). Years count from the start of his reign.

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| c. 930 BC
<i>300 yrs before</i> | ● Prophesied by name
A man of God at Bethel foretells that a son of David named Josiah will burn priests' bones on Jeroboam's altar. <i>1 Kings 13:1-3</i> |
| c. 640 BC
<i>Age 8</i> | ● Crowned king
After servants assassinate his father Amon, the people of the land make young Josiah king. <i>2 Kings 21:23-22:1</i> |
| c. 632 BC
<i>Age 16</i> | ● Begins to seek God
While still young, he begins to seek the God of David his father. <i>2 Chronicles 34:3</i> |
| c. 628 BC
<i>Age 20</i> | ● Purges the land
He tears down high places, Asherah poles and idols in Judah, Jerusalem and the northern tribes. <i>2 Chronicles 34:3-7</i> |
| c. 627 BC
<i>13th year</i> | ● Jeremiah is called
The word of the LORD comes to young Jeremiah; Zephaniah also prophesies. <i>Jeremiah 1:1-2; Zephaniah 1:1</i> |
| c. 622 BC
<i>Age 26</i> | ● The Book is found
Hilkiah finds the Book of the Law in the temple. Josiah hears it, tears his clothes, and consults Huldah. <i>2 Kings 22:3-20</i> |
| c. 622 BC
<i>18th year</i> | ● Covenant and Passover
He reads the Book to all the people, cleanses the land, and keeps a Passover unmatched since Samuel. <i>2 Kings 23:1-25</i> |
| c. 609 BC
<i>Age 39</i> | ● Death at Megiddo
Ignoring Pharaoh Neco's warning, he is shot by archers and dies. Jeremiah laments him. <i>2 Chronicles 35:20-25</i> |

Key activities

Kings tells the reforms after the Book is found; Chronicles puts the first purge six years earlier.

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- I Sought God while young.** His faith began as a personal search at sixteen. *2 Chronicles 34:3*

 - 2 Purged Judah and the north.** He broke down altars, Asherah poles and images and ground them to dust. *2 Chronicles 34:3-7*

 - 3 Repaired the temple.** He paid workers so trusted that no accounting was asked. *2 Kings 22:3-7*

 - 4 Heard the Book and wept.** He tore his clothes when the rediscovered Law was read to him. *2 Kings 22:8-13*

 - 5 Inquired of Huldah.** Judgment would come, but not in his days, because his heart was tender. *2 Kings 22:14-20*

 - 6 Renewed the covenant.** He read the whole Book aloud and pledged the nation to keep it. *2 Kings 23:1-3*

 - 7 Cleansed the temple.** He burned the vessels made for Baal, Asherah and the stars in the Kidron fields. *2 Kings 23:4-7*

 - 8 Ended the high places.** He deposed idol priests and tore down shrines, including Solomon's. *2 Kings 23:5, 8-9, 13-14*

 - 9 Stopped child sacrifice and the occult.** He defiled Topheth and removed the mediums and household idols. *2 Kings 23:10-12, 24*

 - 10 Fulfilled prophecy at Bethel.** He burned bones on Jeroboam's altar but spared the prophet's tomb. *2 Kings 23:15-20*

 - 11 Kept the great Passover.** There had been none like it since Samuel. *2 Kings 23:21-23; 2 Chronicles 35:1-19*

 - 12 Fell at Megiddo.** He would not heed Pharaoh Neco's warning, and he was shot and died. *2 Chronicles 35:20-24*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Josiah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 13:1–3	Named in prophecy; fulfilled in 2 Kings 23:15–18
2 Kings 21:23–23:30	The main account of his reign
2 Chronicles 33:25–35:27	The parallel account, with the Passover in detail
1 Chronicles 3:14–15	Son of Amon; his four sons
Jeremiah 1:2; Zephaniah 1:1	Prophets of his reign
Jeremiah 22:15–16	Praised for justice to the poor
Zechariah 12:11	Mourning at Megiddo, often linked to his death

New Testament

Matthew 1:10–11	In Jesus' line; "Jechonias" is his grandson
Luke 3:23–38	Luke traces the line through Nathan, so Josiah is absent
Echo: John 2:13–17	A son of David cleanses the temple
Echo: Luke 22:7–20	The Passover fulfilled

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Josiah do the moment he heard the Book of the Law (2 Kings 22:11–13)?
2. *Understand:* Huldah said judgment would still come. Why do you think Josiah reformed the nation anyway?
3. *Apply:* Josiah broke with his family's pattern. What habit would you like to break with God's help?
4. *Apply:* Is there a "lost book" in your life, such as Scripture or prayer? What is one step toward it this week?